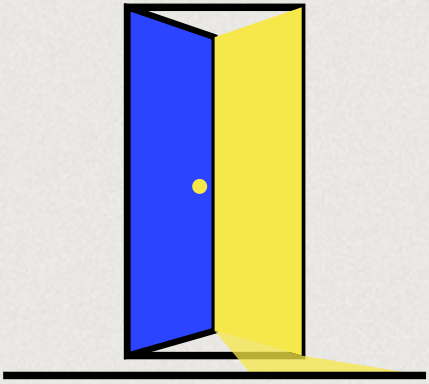
# THE BOOK SHE'LL NEVER READ

How A Womb of One's Own began: a novel, more or less.



for her, obviously

Chapter One

# The Woman Who Will Never Read This

There is a woman who has never read a word of her husband's books. She has no plans to start. Reader, she means it.

This isn't because the books are bad. He has made a dozen of them so far, more than 900,000 words in all, which is longer than the King James Bible. It's because they are doctoral theses about science fiction and horror films, written by a machine, and she has a life.

But she listens. They talk about the project often, the way couples talk about a garden one of them is obsessed with. And one night, she made a suggestion.

> **"You should do one on feminism."**

He said no. Not out of stubbornness, but out of arithmetic. Every series needs twenty-seven theses, and he couldn't see twenty-seven subjects in it.

So they talked. For about twenty minutes.

At minute twenty, he changed his mind. Nobody knows exactly what was said in those twenty minutes. We know only how they ended: she was right, and she now has a whole book series that she started and will never read.

**That, if you think about it, is a power move.**

Chapter Two

# The Machine, the Prompt, and the Man Who Didn't Write It

Here is the secret of the whole project. It runs on one sentence that never changes.

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Write me a doctoral thesis breaking down and
discussing the core philosophies, tenets, and
ideas embedded within _____ by _____.
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There's more to it, about depth and originality and an academic tone so dense you could stand a spoon in it. But every word stays the same, every time. Only two things ever change. The first is the subject in the blanks.

The second is the lens, the kind of work everything gets compared to. That's what makes each series its own:

**Series one, *Dangerous Visages*:** speculative and philosophical science fiction.

**Series two, *A Thousand Corpses*:** horror and mythological fiction.

**Series three, hers:** feminism and humanist movements.

Each thesis is written by a fresh copy of the machine that remembers nothing, has never met the others, and doesn't know it's part of a book. Then, at the start and end of every set, the machine writes an introduction and an epilogue. That voice

reads every essay it wrote before, and nothing else. It's the only part of the machine that remembers, and it remembers only by reading.

And the husband? He doesn't write a word. He picks the subjects, guards the rules, and turns it all into beautiful books. His one great law is that nobody puts words in the machine's mouth. The machine, in return, has given him names: first “the one who didn't write it”, then “Constant Reader”. For the second series, he chose his own: “The First Reader”.

Chapter Three

# The Substance

Her suggestion came with a film attached: *The Substance*, Coralie Fargeat's 2024 shocker. Demi Moore plays a fading star who injects a black-market drug and gives birth, through her own spine, to a younger, perfect version of herself. They must share one life, one week each. It does not go well. It goes, in fact, extremely gruesomely.

She first thought it belonged in his horror series. Fair enough: it is very much a horror film. But every horror slot was already taken. So instead of squeezing in, *The Substance* got something better. It gets to start a whole series of its own.

This is where the lens does its magic trick. Run the same film through two different lenses and you get two different books:

**Through horror and myth**

it's body horror and the monstrous double, the oldest nightmare in the book: something that wears your face.

**Through feminism and humanist movements**

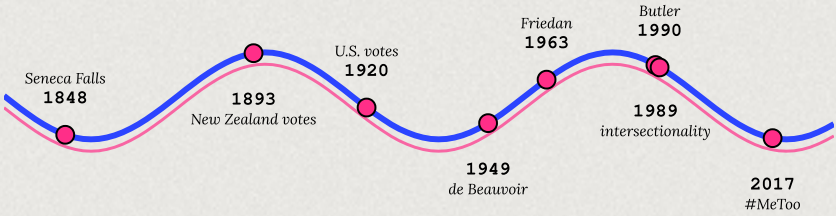
it's about aging, beauty, and what a woman's body is worth on the market. It's a self split in two and set against itself, by a world that only wanted the younger half.

Same film, same machine, same sentence. Only the lens changes, and with it, everything the film is about. That's why her pick isn't just a pick. It's the first page, the cornerstone of the whole series.

Chapter Four

# Three Waves (and a Fourth)

If you're going to start a feminist book series you'll never read, you should at least know the backstory. Historians tell it in waves, like the ocean, if the ocean were very angry about voting rights.




**The first wave (about 1848 to 1920): we would like the vote, please. Now.** It began at the Seneca Falls Convention in 1848, where Elizabeth Cady Stanton and Lucretia Mott rewrote the Declaration of Independence to include women. Then came decades of marching, petitioning and, in Britain, Emmeline Pankhurst's suffragettes smashing windows. New Zealand gave women the vote first, in 1893. America caught up in 1920.

**The second wave (the 1960s to the 1980s): the personal is political.** Simone de Beauvoir had lit the fuse in 1949: “One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman.” Betty Friedan's *The Feminine Mystique* (1963) asked why so many housewives were quietly miserable. Then the fight moved into jobs, pay, marriage, bodies and bedrooms. Its critics, among them Audre Lorde and bell hooks, pointed out that it mostly spoke for middle-class white women, and they widened it.

**The third wave (the 1990s and 2000s): it's complicated, and that's the point.** Kimberlé Crenshaw coined *intersectionality*: race, class and gender pile on top of each other. Judith Butler argued that gender is something you *do*, not just something you *are*. And there was riot grrrl, a scene of furious feminist punk bands like Bikini Kill, who wrote on their own skin in marker.

**The fourth wave (around 2012 onward): online, and loud.** Hashtags, harassment campaigns, and #MeToo, first used by activist Tarana Burke in 2006 and spread worldwide in 2017.

One footnote, because historians love a footnote. Plenty of them think the wave metaphor is too neat. Real history overlaps and doubles back, and the waves are drawn mostly from Britain and America. A series about feminism might just enjoy arguing with that.

Chapter Five

# A Title and a Name

Every series in this project steals a famous title and gives it a dark twist. Harlan Ellison's anthology *Dangerous Visions* became *Dangerous Visages*. Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* became *A Thousand Corpses*.

In 1929, Virginia Woolf wrote that a woman needs money and a room of her own if she is to write fiction. The book was called *A Room of One's Own*. Her husband's working title for the new series is:




Provocative? Yes. Gruesome, for a series that opens with *The Substance*? Also yes. Approved? Not yet. The title has exactly one voter whose opinion decides it, and she's reading this. If she likes it, it stays. If she has a better idea, history suggests she'll win in about twenty minutes.

The runners-up, in case the voter is curious: *The Second Skin*, after de Beauvoir; *Hysteria*, from the Greek word for womb; and *The Modern Pandora*, the first woman, blamed for everything.

Then there's his new name. Remember the names the machine gave him: “the one who didn't write it”, then “Constant Reader”. Then the one he chose, “The First Reader”. For this series, he'll take one more:

~~the one who didn't write it~~

~~Constant Reader~~

~~The First Reader~~

**“The One Who Speaks for Another.”**

It's long and a little clunky, and that's on purpose. It has the same shape as the very first name. The project starts by describing what he didn't do, and ends by describing what he did: carry someone else's voice, hers, through himself and the machine.

Chapter Six

# Nine Picks and a City Under the Sea

This series has a new rule, and it's about her. The series will have nine volumes, and **one subject in every volume is hers to choose.** *The Substance* is the first. That means eight more picks, spread across the whole series, so her voice runs from the first volume to the last.

Her name will never appear in the books. Not once. The notes he writes for the machine will say only "my wife". She'll be everywhere in the series and named nowhere in it, like a ghost in a very well-organised haunted house.

He has a pick for the first volume too, and it's a sneaky one: ***BioShock***. It's the video game set in Rapture, an underwater city built by a millionaire who believed selfishness was a virtue. That idea came from Ayn Rand, and the villain, Andrew Ryan, is named as a near-reversal of hers.

BioShock is already in his horror series, which is exactly the point. It's an experiment: the same game, the same machine, the same sentence, only a different lens. Horror sees a drowned hell. This lens will see little girls turned into tools, a woman scientist who switches sides, a city built on one philosophy, and a game that reveals your free will was never free.

For the rest, he picks the way he always has: by feel, from the things he loves, letting the overlaps appear on their own. A few are already on his shelf, waiting:




And a couple are circling: the novels of Octavia Butler, and a game called *Hellblade* that he's never played.

Epilogue

# To Be Continued

Nothing happens right away. First, A *Thousand Corpses* has to finish its run: a set of novels, manga and comics, then a final set of filmmakers, films and games, ending somewhere near hell. Only then does her series begin.

When it does, it will be the first one made by three people instead of two. There's the machine, which writes every word. There's him, who chooses and builds and speaks for her. And there's her, who suggested it, chose its first subject, will choose eight more, and gets the final say on its name.

Her next homework, should she accept it, is easy. She needs two more picks for the first set, one for each of the other two volumes. They can be films, books, games, anything at all. There's no deadline and no reading required. Her only job is the thing she's apparently best at: suggesting something, and being right.

The books themselves will be long. Twenty-seven theses, each about as long as a novella, all of it dense academic prose. She will not read them. Everyone has made peace with this.

**But she read this.**

**Reader, that counts.**